

‘Kristallnacht’ – The Night of a Broken Glass

Vaishali Narkar and Sanjeev Khandekar

2022

www.vaishaliandsanjeev.com

In ‘*Kristallnacht*’ - *The Night of Broken Glass : Kashmir*, Vaishali and Sanjeev reimagine the geography of Kashmir through the aesthetics of fracture, memory, and mourning. Across fifteen works - paintings, mixed-media compositions, embroidery on paper and canvas, and intimate postcard-scale pieces - the artists construct a visual archive of violence and endurance. Borrowing their title from the Nazi pogrom of 1938, the ‘The Night of Broken Glass’, they transpose its resonant metaphor of shattered civility onto the prolonged political and human crisis of Kashmir.

The series engages directly with maps: colonial cartographies, military charts, and outlines of territory, each transformed into a palimpsest of erasures and scars. The use of mirror images of old British maps disorients the viewer’s sense of geography and history, evoking how narratives of Kashmir are often reversed, refracted, or misread. The maps - objects of imperial control - become unstable surfaces, broken by impact marks that resemble bullet holes or shattering glass. In some works, actual fractured glass overlays the maps, creating a tactile, physical tension between surface and violence. In others, the artists meticulously paint or draw the illusion of cracks - veins of trauma radiating outward like frozen explosions.

The recurring image of the wound, whether through punctured paper, burnt marks, or needlework, becomes central to the series. Embroidery, traditionally associated with repair and domestic labour, here takes on an ambivalent symbolism: both healing and hurting. Red thread marks and stitched buds populate the terrain of Kashmir like seeds or lesions - simultaneously bleeding and blooming. The artists describe these buds as “opening like wounds, or like hopes,” articulating the paradox of a landscape where suffering and beauty coexist inseparably.

Another motif, the half apple - painted, embroidered, and placed with precision on the map - extends this vocabulary of paradox. The apple, quintessential to Kashmir’s agricultural identity, appears halved, its core visible like an exposed organ, exposes its core - a heart cut open. It becomes both a local symbol and a universal image of violation and resilience. The gesture of division echoes the political partitioning of the region, while its fleshy openness suggests vulnerability and fertility in equal measure. The apple becomes the land itself: cut, displayed, yet defiantly alive.

Through material and metaphor, ‘Kristallnacht’ - *The Night of Broken Glass : Kashmir* transforms the political cartography, Kristallnacht becomes a meditation on the poetics of damage. It challenges the neutrality of cartographic representation by exposing the emotional and political undercurrents it conceals. Through cracked surfaces, stitched skins, and mirrored terrains, Vaishali and Sanjeev create a fragile topography of remembrance, where every wound is also a mark of life, and every fracture, a mirror reflecting the persistence of hope.



Title: 'Kristallnacht' – The Night of a Broken Glass
Medium: Embroidery, acrylic, pastels, pen and an interfere on canvas
Size: 30" x 42"
Year: 2022



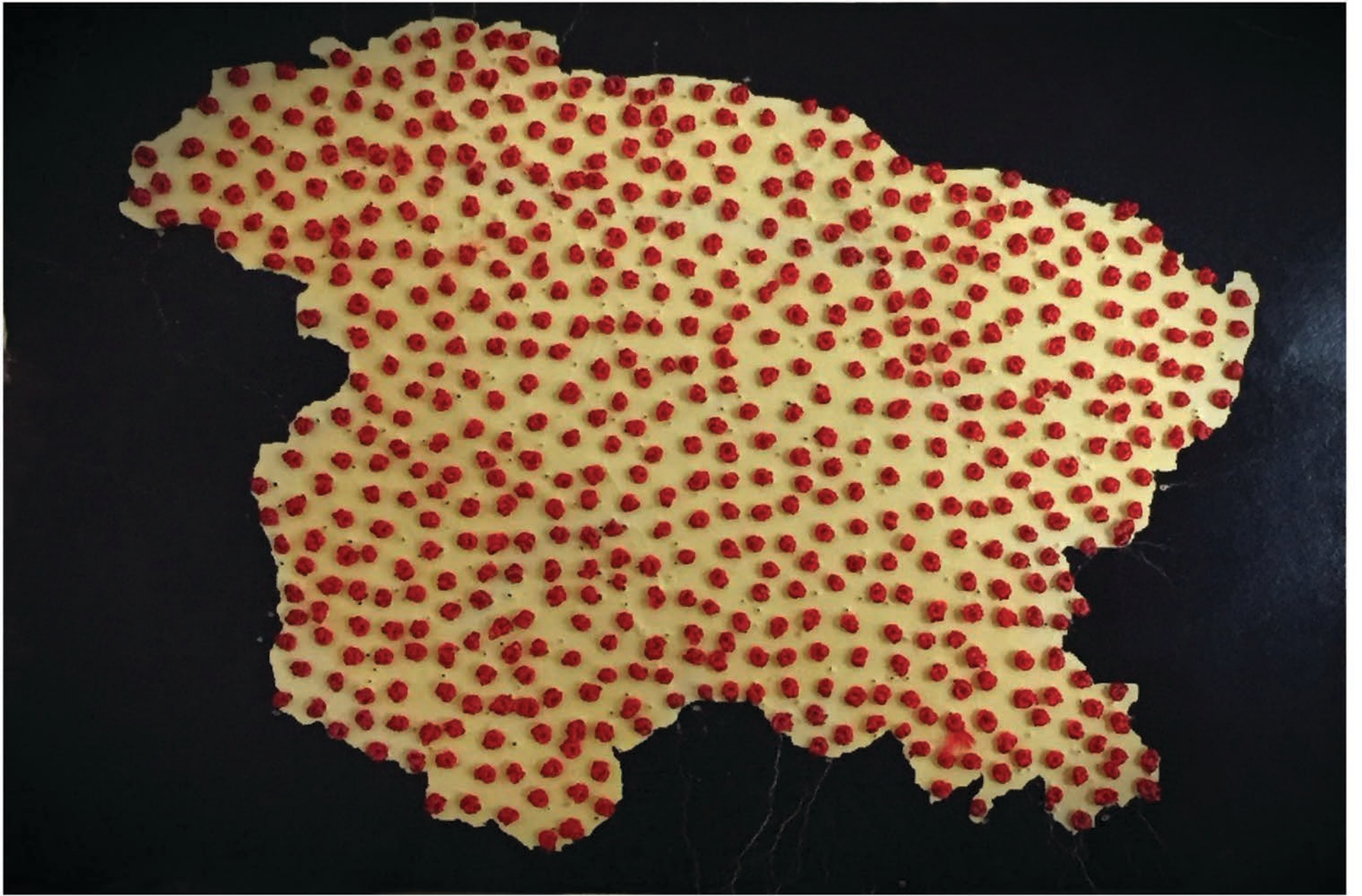
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Title: 'Kristallnacht' – The Night of a Broken Glass
Medium: Acrylic, pastels, pen & a interface on canva
Size: 30" x 42"
Year: 2014



Title: 'Kristallnacht' – The Night of a Broken Glass
Medium: Embroidery, acrylic, on postcard
Size: 48" x 60"
Year: 2014